

cover story AVIATION

hours, the queue could stretch over 500 ft, and it could take over two hours before a passenger, who has joined at the tail end, reaches one of the counters. "Tell me, why should I return to India?" fumes Teng Kiat (58), Iskcon devotee and a sports shop owner in Kuala Lumpur.

Flying may have once been the preserve of the rich, but the advent of the low-cost airlines has changed all that. Such is the boom that air travellers often liken airports to old railway stations and bus terminals. Take the Delhi airport, for instance. Built to handle 13 million passengers per year, India's second busiest airport—which is expected to overtake Mumbai in two years to become the busiest—works at near 200 per cent capacity. Last year, it handled 23 million passengers. In the past four years alone, the aviation sector has more than doubled. Each day over 3,800 flights fly nearly 3.5 lakh passengers. To meet the rising demand, three new commercial aircraft are added every month to a current fleet of 385.

You would think the problem would be bad in provincial airports, but the situation is worst in Mumbai and Delhi which account for over half the country's air traffic. Yes, mammoth redevelopment work is on for new airports to be opened in 2010 but nobody seems to have planned for the interim. The inconvenience assumes monumental proportions as massive areas are cordoned off adding confusion to the reigning chaos. The air crush is taxing every essential aspect of the airports, from safety and security to air traffic control.

It would have been clear five years back that the modest Indian airports were not quite adequate to accommodate the galloping pace of traffic growth. But then this is India where post facto planning is the ruling mantra and post haste merely a phrase. Every airport was built as a symbol of socialist self-reliance, not as a model that could be scaled for efficiency. Single runways—or as in Mumbai, a bizarre cross-runway—and concrete terminals where pillars occupy more space than counters are the templates. If there is

COUNTDOWN TO TAKE-OFF

From the time one enters the airport, it takes at least four hours to board a flight



Graphic by SAURABH SINGH and MADHU MANGAL SINGH

NEARLY 3.5 LAKH PASSENGERS,
ENOUGH TO FILL OVER **850**
JUMBO JETS, FLY EVERY DAY IN
ABOUT **3,800** FLIGHTS